capital, Beijing, mourning his death, with university students gathering in the historic Tiananmen Square. Hu was regarded by the students as a champion of more liberal policies. The demonstrations soon escalated into insistent demands for political freedoms and democracy. Chinese political leaders delayed taking action to suppress the demonstrations because of the impending visit of the Soviet Leader Mikhail Gorbachev to Beijing during 15–18 May 1989. However, the visit further encouraged the demonstrators because a large number of international journalists and TV crews had gathered in Beijing to cover Gorbachev's visit, which would mark the normalization of Sino-Soviet relations after a period of thirty years. The international media coverage would give the demonstrators unprecedented global publicity, which was precisely what transpired. Gorbachev himself was seen as a relatively young and reforming figure.

In a conversation later that year with Indian Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi, Gorbachev said that he had received a note from the Chinese students bearing the figures '58-85', conveying that as a relatively young leader at fifty-eight he should avoid talking to the old man of eighty-five that was Deng Xiaoping. His visit to Beijing further galvanized the students. A few student leaders overreached, enjoying their celebrity status in the international media. It was only a question of time before this challenge to authority was crushed. On 4 June 1989, the PLA was ordered to clear the historic square, killing and injuring several thousand students and ordinary citizens in the process. Zhao Ziyang was removed from office and his place was taken by Jiang Zemin, who was then heading the party organization in the city of Shanghai.

Gorbachev's view was that the CPC had gone wrong by focusing only on economic reforms and liberalization but neglecting political reforms, or 'perestroika', which he himself had initiated in his country. On 15 May 1989, while in Beijing, he expressed his views to his delegation on the implications of the Tiananmen demonstrations:'Some of those present here have promoted the idea of taking the Chinese road. We saw today where this road leads. I do not want the Red Square to look like Tiananmen Square.' [2] And yet, it is an irony of history that the CPC eventually proved